

Budget networking

Facebook has partnered with Snaptu, presenting a Facebook app for low-end handsets

'Personal' videos

YouTube has given its homepage a snugger fit, with "personally relevant" content

Sony Gameplay: NGP

Sony has finally announced the PSP2, calling it the "Next Generation Portable" device (NGP). With the NGP, Sony looks to offer the "ultimate portable entertainment" using some killer hardware and cross-platform software.

The PSP2 is packed with a quad-core ARM Cortex-A9 processor, dual analog sticks, front and rear cameras, dual rear touchpads, a high-resolution 960x544 pixel 5-inch OLED capacitive touchscreen, accelerometer/gyroscope (courtesy the PS Move controller), digital compass, GPS, and yes, both 3G and Wi-Fi connectivity.

Game developers such as Capcom, Konami, Epic Games, Tecmo Koei and Sega also likened it to the PlayStation 3 console in terms of graphics. Game titles include *Resistance*, *Killzone*, *Little Big Planet*, *Uncharted*, *Metal*

GearSolid, *Monster Hunter*, *Dynasty Warriors*, and more.

With a touchscreen, rear touchpads, and dual analog sticks in tow, the Next Generation Portable will certainly be offering a surfeit of input/interface options. The PSP2's menu UI is a heavily customised Android 2.3 interface with navigable homescreens, and in-built location-based social-networking called LiveArea.



Sony plans to release the NGP only by the end of the year ("holiday" season) and much of that time remaining will be spent concentrating on creating the device's hardware-agnostic platform and library of game titles that will be called the PlayStation Suite. **[d]**

Android Market finally gets a web store

The Android Market has finally joined the rest of the other major platform-owned mobile app stores (from Ovi to Apple to BlackBerry) by launching a web version of the store – market.android.com. Now users have the opportunity to download Android Market applications on the web.

In addition to a clean interface, the app download process is pretty straightforward – pay if required via Google Checkout, choose your device, click install, and the app arrives over-the-air.

All this makes web access of the Android Market a definite boon for those not in Wi-Fi areas, or those lacking or not wanting to use their mobile GPRS/EDGE or 3G connectivity.

But, the uncertain and sometimes expensive nature of mobile data usage/connectivity is not the only reason for the creation of a web mobile app store. App dis-

covery is much easier on larger screens, there are numerous advantages for the app developers themselves.

Google has also announced some other long-awaited benefits to developers, introducing in-app purchases and thereby opening up a world of add-on content, promotion and cross-promotion – monetarily



exciting for developers, even those creating free applications. Developers will also be able to offer their apps across various markets in different currencies, and so avoid the rough, unrounded numbers common with currency conversions. **[d]**

Nvidia GT 440 and GTX 560 Ti

Nvidia has updated its desktop graphics card lineup with two new Fermi-derived GPUs: the GeForce GTX 560 Ti and GeForce GT 440.

The 560 Ti, sitting square in between the AMD Radeon HD 6950 and the HD 6870, has prompted some decisive wran-



gling in the \$200 to \$300 GPU segment, with AMD's two new variants to balance the competition. Priced at \$249, the GTX 560 Ti now sits between a cheaper 1GB VRAM variant of the HD 6950, priced at \$259, and factory over-clocked versions of the HD 6870, priced at approximately \$230. AMD has also released a series of Catalyst (v11.2 at the time of writing) drivers, upping performance incrementally across the HD 5800, 6800, and 6900 series.

The GeForce GTX 560 Ti is

based on what Nvidia is calling the GF114 GPU architecture, which rather than being something new entirely, is more along the lines of a fully enabled 1.95 billion transistor GF104 (GTX 460), with no locked or non-functional cores, engines, ROPs, and memory controllers. It also has much faster clocks (147 MHz faster core clock, 102 MHz faster memory clock, and 296 MHz increase in shader clock).

With the GT 440, Nvidia is now offering consumers retail version of a card that has been



available with OEMs since last year, with a few changes and streamlined improvements. Available from most of its add-on partners, the GT 440 is an entry-level gaming desktop card, meant for HTPC as well. **[d]**